

Karthyayani (68), children Rithvik (8) and Rishvik (3 months), and his niece Anu Lakshmi (14). For Biju, an idle pursuit has led to fame and a livelihood; indeed, his days now revolve around chronicling his family life.

Rithvik does not reveal numbers, but says he earns "enough" to support his family as a content creator. Says Biju, "I do not know who invented YouTube and other platforms, but they are a blessing for people like me." ■

M.G. Arun

beerbiceps) set up Monk Entertainment aka Monk-E, a creative digital media organisation aimed at bridging the gap between influencers and brands. Today, it represents some 120 creators across domains that include food, beauty, fashion, travel, lifestyle, podcast and technology. Among them is fashion creator Nancy Tyagi, who turned heads at Cannes last year with a striking pink gown that she designed herself. "Content creators are like five companies packed into one," says Sheth. "For brands, it reduces their cost significantly, gives them better relatability with audiences and facilitates far more ease of communication." It's why they are choosing creators over the pricey, even fussy, Bollywood and sports celebs for quicker, targeted communication.

INDIA'S CREATOR ECONOMY IS NOT AN EXCLUSIVELY GEN Z PHENOMENON OR A PREDOMINANTLY METRO TREND—IT'S AN INDUSTRY THAT WELCOMES EVERYONE

The Covid pandemic deepened the trend, opening up a wealth of opportunities for creators, primary among them a captive audience seeking to escape the dystopia outside. With access to celebrities restricted, brands increasingly turned to creators who not only acted, directed and distributed their content, but also had an active online presence and highly engaged communities.

Influencer marketing is not just empowering creators but also translating into money. The Goat India Influencer Marketing Report, 2025, valued the industry at Rs 3,600 crore in 2024, projected a growth of 25 per cent in 2025. "The new marketing model has evolved from just building brand salience to capturing attention and driving engagement. Influencers have been central to this shift by creating authentic, relatable relationships with their followers," says Pratik Ved, vice president—skin care, Hindustan Unilever Limited. HUL has collaborated with digital creators like Ankush Bahuguna and Komal Pandey for campaigns across brands such as Dove, Simple, Ponds and Vaseline. "It's no longer just about follower count," Ved adds. "We look for influencers whose values align with the brand, who speak authentically, and who have a meaningful connection with their audience."

According to industry insiders, a beauty, fashion and lifestyle creator with a million followers and engagement of 50,000-700,000 views can earn Rs 5-10 lakh for a reel and Rs 2-3 lakh for an Insta story. Meanwhile, a popular entertainment creator with the same reach can earn Rs 80 lakh-1.5 crore a year. Instagram also has 'Born on Instagram', which connects brands to creators, and a Creator Marketplace to further strengthen the partnership.

Among its benefeciaries is Pune's Madhura Bachal (@madhurarecipe Marathi), 45, who best demonstrates the entrepreneurial streak of India's creators. One of the earliest to join YouTube back in 2008 with the goal of putting Maharashtrian cuisine on the world map, the former banker began by shooting videos when her baby was asleep. In 2016, she realised she would gain subscribers far more quickly if she went local, and so started another channel in Marathi. Today, apart from running three channels and writing 12 books, Madhura has her own line of spices and kitchen appliances, which she retails online. "I am making more as a content creator than I did as a banker," she says, revealing how she makes a six to seven-figure sum monthly from brand collaborations and content monetisation. It is a matter of intense pride and joy when she sees popular food creators like chef Ranveer Brar, YourFoodLab and Kabita's Kitchen post Maharashtrian recipes.